

GENERAL TECHNIQUES

Quiltmaking involves different techniques at different stages, but many techniques are the same, whether the quilt is pieced, appliquéd, or

wholecloth. The techniques outlined in this section are key, whichever type of quilt you choose to make. You will use them over and over again.

► PRE-WASHING AND PREPARING FABRICS

While many people are divided on whether to pre-wash fabric or not, if you plan to wash a finished project in the future it is usually a good idea to pre-wash the fabrics before you cut or sew them together. Different fabrics shrink at different rates, so pre-washing will help avoid uneven shrinkage, and therefore puckering, when the

finished item is first washed. Pre-washing fabrics can also help to remove any excess dye, which can leech out and discolour the other fabrics. Small pre-cuts do not need to be washed before use as the washing process may ruin them. Check before pre-washing any pre-cut fabrics.

PRE-WASHING FABRICS

There are many things to consider when deciding whether to pre-wash your fabrics or not:

Shrinkage The quality and type of fabric will yield different percentages of shrinkage. You can expect the shrinkage of cotton to be anywhere from 3mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ in) to 1.2cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ in). If you choose not to pre-wash your fabric, but do wash them in the future, the fabrics may pucker or distort as they each shrink at different rates and in different directions to one another. Therefore, a quilt made from pre-washed fabrics will stay flatter and look more even after washing. However, many people prefer this crinkly look and feel it gives a quilt a vintage feel. Most manufacturers' washing instructions are given on the bolt, so note these down when purchasing the fabric.

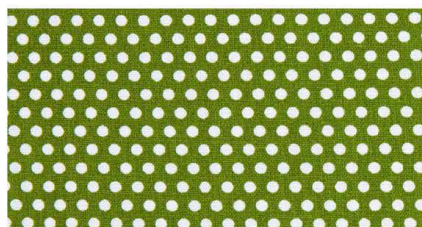
Bleeding While it is not a guarantee, pre-washing a fabric may help to remove any excess dye from it. Certain colours – such as reds, blues, and purples – are more prone to bleeding than others. You can test a small piece of the fabric for colourfastness by submerging it in a clear bowl of warm, soapy water and leaving it to sit. After about 30 minutes to an hour, place the bowl on a white surface and check to see if the water has changed colour. If the water has, you know that the item is not colourfast and will

bleed when washed. If the water has not changed colour, leave the wet piece of fabric to sit on a scrap of white fabric. If the colour transfers to the white fabric after a short period of time then the fabric is not colourfast. If it does not, the fabric is colourfast.

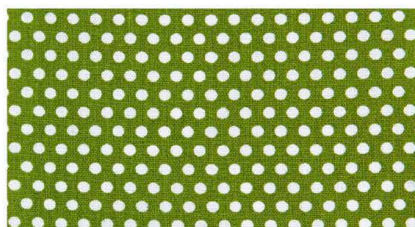
If the fabric is not colourfast, you should pre-wash it several times using a dye magnet or colour catcher. After each wash cycle, perform the colourfastness tests to check if any dye still remains. Continue to pre-wash the fabric until it no longer bleeds. You can also buy colour fastener to treat a fabric. Follow the manufacturer's instructions.

Handling and chemicals Fabric right off the bolt usually contains sizing and other chemicals to help protect it. These make the fabric easier to cut and machine sew, but may not be suitable for people sensitive to chemicals. If you pre-wash it to remove the chemical, pressing your washed fabric well will help to set the fibres and allow for more precise cutting and piecing.

What will the finished item be used for? If you are making an item for display, such as a wall hanging, there may be no need to pre-wash the fabrics, as they will probably never be washed in the future.



NEW FABRIC



WASHED FABRIC

This swatch shows what can happen to a piece of cotton fabric during washing. Some of the dye bled out and the fabric shrank.